

Chapter 76_1 - Wishes

The surrounding clamor and lights seemed to fade away as Chu Qingqiu watched those wind chimes swaying in the breeze, a look of disbelief flashing in her eyes.

Her previously pale complexion was replaced by a rosy flush, though it couldn't be seen clearly in the dim lamplight. Her eyes reflected the river of lights as she released her already aching hands.

"I never believe in such things." she said.

With that, she turned and walked away through the bustling crowd in the opposite direction. Ning Fuyi withdrew the air currents from her palm and hurried to follow.

Chu Qingqiu walked far until the crowd around them was no longer as dense as on the Marriage Bridge, then slowly stopped, her hair brushing past her cheek as she suppressed the tremors in her heart.

"Divine Venerable! Why did you walk so fast?" Ning Fuyi dodged past several children holding candied hawthorns, her hair flowing as she stopped in front of Chu Qingqiu. Whether from running or the lamplight's reflection, her complexion also had a rosy tint.

"I didn't get a chance to ask earlier - you usually don't like coming down the mountain. Why are you here joining in the mortal Qixi Festival festivities?" Ning Fuyi's words came in a rush as soon as she saw Chu Qingqiu, asking one question after another.

Chu Qingqiu steadied her mind and turned around as usual: "Jiang Li... Jiang Li had business with you, so I came down with her."

"Medical Immortal Jiang?" Ning Fuyi's face lit up. "Could it be that she's thought of a cure?"

Chu Qingqiu's red lips moved, but in the end she didn't speak, only saying: "Something like that. When you see her, ask her yourself."

"Good." Ning Fuyi nodded. She had thought her headaches would plague her for years, but unexpectedly Jiang Li had found a solution so quickly. She truly was the most renowned medical immortal.

"Where is Medical Immortal Jiang?" Ning Fuyi asked. Chu Qingqiu looked up and around - all she could see were seas of lights and people of all kinds. Jiang Li was nowhere to be found.

"She and Qiuyi forced me onto the bridge together earlier. They've probably reached the other end by now." Chu Qingqiu shook her head distantly.

"Qiuyi and Medical Immortal Jiang could actually make you go." Ning Fuyi said, half-serious and half-joking.

Chu Qingqiu dimmed the ripples in her eyes and didn't respond to Ning Fuyi's words.

"Jiuying came with me too, but we got separated. Maybe they'll meet up on the bridge." Ning Fuyi curved her eyes with a smile, raising her hand to her brow to summon Jiuying, but when she looked up and saw half of Chu Qingqiu's profile, her thoughts suddenly shifted.

She lowered her hand, pretending to be troubled: "I just formed a contract with a divine beast and haven't learned how to communicate with it properly yet. Since this town is only so big, why don't we walk ahead and wait for them at the liveliest spot?"

"I heard earlier that there'll be a sea of lights blessing ceremony, and apparently some novel attractions. Since the Divine Venerable has nothing else to do, shall we go take a look first?" Ning Fuyi raised a bright smile.

Chu Qingqiu was about to decline when Ning Fuyi suddenly reached out to pinch her sleeve, tugging her toward the road.

"Come on, Divine Venerable." she said.

Ning Fuyi rarely acted so obediently, especially with such a face making such careful, tentative gestures.

Very well - it was just strolling through the mortal world. She could think of it as greedily leaving herself some memories before her death. Chu Qingqiu hooked her fingertip around her own sleeve, gently pulling it from Ning Fuyi's palm.

"Mm." she said, lowering her gaze.

Seeing her agreement, Ning Fuyi felt a secret joy rising in her heart. She stuffed the rabbit lantern that Rong Jin had bought into Chu Qingqiu's hands: "Let's go! If we wait any longer, there'll be even more people and we really won't be able to get through!"

Chu Qingqiu found the rabbit lantern childish, holding it with just two slender fingers, but seeing how happy Ning Fuyi was, she barely tolerated it, carrying the childish lamp into the crowd.

"Divine Venerable, look - that person's magic tricks really look like immortal arts. If he didn't lack immortal power, I'd really think he was a sect disciple secretly performing on the street." Ning Fuyi chattered nonstop along the way.

"These sugar cakes smell so good. Shopkeeper, two please!"

"Divine Venerable, do you like this hairpin?"

"Eh, the flower lantern went out."

"Divine Venerable..."

"Ning Fuyi." Chu Qingqiu suddenly stuffed the sugar cake that had been forced into her hands into Ning Fuyi's mouth, blocking her endless stream of words. "Why are you talking so much?"

"I'm not some gluttonous little girl who loves sweets. Besides, I never liked eating sweet things. Keep it for yourself." Chu Qingqiu withdrew her hand into her sleeves, turned to leave, then remembered something and turned back to stuff the flower lantern she'd been carrying back to Ning Fuyi as well.

Her peach blossom eyes swept over Ning Fuyi, she shook her head, then turned and disappeared into the crowd.

Ning Fuyi had by now almost completely accepted Chu Qingqiu's temperament. She felt not a trace of anger, even keeping her smile as she threw everything into her Thought Pearl and followed with curved lips.

The closer they got to the town center, the more crowded the passing crowds became. Chu Qingqiu didn't like bumping into people and was dodging sideways when the woman beside her suddenly moved in front of her, using her straight, delicate back to part the crowd for her.

Chu Qingqiu looked at the hair hanging over Ning Fuyi's shoulders and was momentarily lost in thought.

"Divine Venerable, look - this is what the townspeople called the novel attraction." Ning Fuyi suddenly stepped aside, opening Chu Qingqiu's view so she could see the full appearance of the thing.

"Mechanical arts¹?" Chu Qingqiu said, looking up at the massive object bound to the high platform. The bottom looked like a ship, apparently made of refined steel, while the top was composed of many pieces of black iron that slowly rotated, floating in mid-air.

Just getting slightly close, one could detect air currents flowing from it. The townspeople all around didn't dare approach, whispering to each other in amazement.

"So this is what the townspeople were talking about." Ning Fuyi was also quite amazed. "When did the mechanical arts of the immortal sects spread to the mortal world?"

"This is a Dragon War Ship, the handiwork of Sect Master Hua Hong of the Flying Flower Sect². There's not a trace of immortal power in it - it's entirely composed of ingenious mechanisms. You only need to turn a handle to soar through the sky." Chu Qingqiu looked up at it.

The Flying Flower Sect was different from the other five sects. They didn't only focus on cultivation methods and spiritual power - the entire sect was skilled in mechanical arts, especially their sect master Hua Hong's mechanical arts, which were unparalleled under heaven.

Seeing the crowd below the platform packed tight, someone finally walked onto the platform. Dressed in brocade and fine clothes, with a gold lock at his waist and jewels glittering on his fingertips, he smiled broadly: "Everyone, everyone!"

He shouted at the top of his voice several times before the densely packed townspeople below quieted down.

"Everyone has seen that this object is called a Dragon War Ship - an immortal sect treasure that we mortals cannot obtain! Fortunately, this humble merchant has made many friends and has extensive connections, which is how I obtained this item to open everyone's eyes in Starpoint Town!"

"Soon the annual Sea of Lights blessing ceremony will begin. If you can board this ship and stand in the sea of lights, then your heart's wishes will be more easily heard by heaven." The man's fat face was full of smiles. "The Dragon War Ship only ascends once - everyone must seize this opportunity and not miss this auspicious moment!"

"Merchant Zhang! Don't just shout - you must first tell us how we can get on!" A thin young man in the crowd raised his arm.

The man chuckled and held up a finger: "Ten taels of silver."

"Ten taels of silver! Why don't you just rob us!" the young man shouted angrily. Others also began complaining and turned to leave.

"Ten taels of silver - how long would I have to sell sugar cakes to earn that!" someone complained.

"Yes, no matter how precious immortal sect items are, praying for blessings is just for psychological comfort. What fate is meant to come still can't be avoided - why waste this unjust money!"

Seeing everyone scatter, the man immediately panicked and began jumping up and down, stroking his beard: "Don't leave, everyone! The price is negotiable! Eight taels! Five taels!"

Seeing he was about to lose everything, the man broke into a sweat: "One tael! One tael should be acceptable!"

As soon as he finished speaking, a pale white hand suddenly appeared before his eyes, placing several silver coins in his palm.

Looking up, he saw a tall, beautiful woman with features like unsheathed sword light - not as cold and hard as a blade's edge, but equally imposing. The sight made the man's sweat instantly dry up.

"Hurry and launch the ship. Don't miss the auspicious time." the woman smiled.

After about an incense stick's worth of time, the Dragon War Ship was soaring through the sky. The clouds overhead seemed within reach, while below them lights shone everywhere as countless sky lanterns were lit. With the sound of drums, they slowly rose into the air.

Cool wind brushed past their ears as Chu Qingqiu stood at the ship's stern, letting the gauze below her shoulders flutter brilliantly, gazing at the bright moon in the distance.

Perhaps tonight the mortal world was too bright, making even the stars dim, as if the sky's radiance had been stolen by the mortal world and ignited in those countless mortal lamps.

"We're cultivators - if we wanted to fly, we could just use our swords. Why go to all this trouble?" Chu Qingqiu shook her head.

"We can use our swords any day, but the chance to ride this Dragon War Ship together to watch the lights from the sky doesn't come every day." Ning Fuyi smiled, handing Chu Qingqiu a red paper from her hand.

"This is what that merchant gave me earlier. He said Starpoint Town's custom is to write down your wishes, then paste them on sky lanterns to send to heaven, and the blessing is complete."

"The sky lanterns are coming up, quickly!" Ning Fuyi said, taking out an ink stick, breaking it in half and handing one piece to Chu Qingqiu, then turning her back to begin writing.

How could she believe in such blessing tricks? She was just following a whim, wanting to stand a little longer in this brilliant sea of lights.

Her fingertips rubbed the ink stick, getting her hands black. She turned slightly to look at Chu Qingqiu and found her staring at the red paper in her hands, lost in thought.

Her heart began beating wildly again.

Ning Fuyi turned back and wrote seriously with her brush: "I only wish that in this life, I will lose nothing more."

After writing, she didn't hesitate, throwing the red paper out from the Dragon War Ship. The paper immediately flew away with the wind, disappearing among the sky lanterns that had already surrounded them.

"Divine Venerable, what did you write..." Ning Fuyi smiled as she turned around, only to find that Chu Qingqiu had somehow already finished writing, her fingertip holding the red paper out into the wind.

"Just something random - nothing more than praying for peace for all living beings." Chu Qingqiu said indifferently.

Ning Fuyi wasn't surprised. The Chu Qingqiu in her heart would naturally write something about all living beings, the six realms, universal peace, and so on. She bent down to continue watching the magnificent mortal world.

But she didn't see the threads of tenderness in those eyes watching her back.

The words on that paper had already flown away with the wind, but they weren't about all living beings - they were a single sentence.

"Whatever she seeks, may it all be as I wish."

Then tonight, this brilliant display of lights that she allowed herself to watch would be another grand memory, enough for her to hold in her heart and slowly savor for another ten or hundred years.

Footnotes:

¹ Mechanical arts (机关术) - Ancient Chinese engineering and mechanical contraptions, often elaborate devices using gears, pulleys, and other mechanisms

² Flying Flower Sect (飞花教) - One of the six major sects mentioned in the story, specializing in mechanical arts rather than just cultivation